SQUASH AND PEPITA TARTLETS

makes 10 to 12 tartlets

When ground with a little oil and sweetener, pepitas form a dough that creates a crisp, crunchy shell for these little tartlets, filled with roasted squash and apple. (As a topping, you can toss some pumpkin seeds and amaranth with maple syrup and bake for a few minutes until crunchy.) Like all Indigenous desserts, this one is free of refined sugar, wheat, and dairy, and it's also nutrient-dense.

Make the filling: Preheat the oven to 350°F. Line a baking sheet with parchment paper.

Set the seeded squash on the baking sheet cut-side down and bake until very soft, about 1 hour. (Leave the oven on.) Discard the squash skin and measure out 2 packed cups of roasted squash.

Let the boiling water sit for 1 minute before using. Place the dried pineapple weed or chamomile in a mug and pour the hot water over it to steep for 5 minutes. Strain the tea, discarding the solids.

In a food processor or blender, combine the 2 cups of roasted squash with the apple chunks, maple syrup, and salt. Add ½ cup of the tea and puree for about 1 minute, until smooth, adding more tea if necessary to achieve a smooth consistency. (You'll have about 2½ cups.)

Scrape into a saucepan and set over medium-high heat. Whisk in the agar-agar and simmer for 2 minutes, or until the filling thickens.

Make the tart shells: Lightly oil 12 cups of a standard muffin tin or ten 4-ounce ramekins, then line each with strips of parchment paper (to make pulling out the tartlets easier).

In a food processor, pulse the pepitas and amaranth flour until the seeds are finely chopped. With the machine on, add the oil, ¼ cup water, the maple syrup, and agave and let it run until it holds together like a dough.

Press the dough evenly into the bottoms and up the sides of the prepared muffin cups or ramekins (to create tart shells). (Use about 2 tablespoons per muffin cup.) If the dough gets sticky, wet your hands with a little water as you press.

Pipe or spoon equal amounts of the filling into the tart shells. (Use about 3 tablespoons of filling per muffin cup.) If using ramekins, place them on a baking sheet.

Bake for 15 to 20 minutes, until the crust is browned at the edges and the filling is dry to the touch on top.

Let cool in the pan or ramekins for 10 minutes, then carefully lift out the tarts and transfer to a rack to fully cool. Serve at room temperature or cover and refrigerate and serve chilled.

FILLING

- 2-pound piece Lakota winter squash, red kuri squash, or kabocha squash, seeded
- 1 cup boiling water
- 1 teaspoon dried pineapple weed or chamomile
- 1 Gala apple, cored and cut into chunks but not peeled
- ½ cup maple syrup
- 1 teaspoon fine sea salt
- ½ teaspoon agar-agar powder

TART SHELLS

- ¼ cup sunflower oil, plus more for muffin tin
- 8 ounces pepitas (about 2 cups)
- ¼ cup amaranth flour
- 1½ teaspoons maple syrup
- 2 teaspoons agave syrup